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UC-Berkeley campus community reminisces together

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(*#_Company_Name_#*) BERKELEY, Calif. -- Red, white and blue ribbons, along with white ribbons, were passed out, and "The Star-Spangled Banner" was sung as last week's controversy fizzled into a calm day of reflection.

The first anniversary of Sept. 11 came and went with numerous memorials and a quiet surge of political tension.

UC police said there were no Sept. 11-related crimes or incidents, and students were able to openly express their political differences.

Thousands of students gathered on Sproul Plaza at noon, observing the campuswide moment of silence. Some students passed out U.S. flags, while others draped themselves in flags.

A group of students wore black clothing and white ribbons, saying they chose to mourn the deaths of Sept. 11 in a more "inclusive" way.

"We completely agree with a non-political commemoration of the day," said Cal-SERVE Senator Mary Boktor. "(But) we opted to wear black and wear white ribbons to promote an inclusive commemoration of the victims of Sept. 11 as well as the victims of hate crimes and innocent civilians in Afghanistan."

Approximately two dozen students wearing identical black T-shirts lined up, holding up blue flags picturing the Earth. Their shirts read, "Our grief is not a cry for war."

"We need to understand that victims from 9/11 are from all over, and if we wrap ourselves in flags and glorify the flag, that inadvertently disallows remembrance for all people's suffering," said a UC Berkeley student wearing the shirt, who wished to remain anonymous.

Memorial organizers said they decided not to distribute ribbons of various colors because the day's events took much planning.

But some students said the participants in black T-shirts detracted from the event.

"It was unfortunate that some groups tried to make the event political," said Robb McFadden, a member of the Berkeley College Republicans. "Although there were an array of opinions, people were able to reflect in their own way."

Despite these differences, many participants of yesterday's events agreed the memorials provided an open and respectful environment for people of all political and religious beliefs.

"I think it was a good balance of views and sentiments," said UC Berkeley spokesperson Marie Felde.

Many speakers urged students to come together in grief and tolerance.

"Today is not about politics," said ASUC President Jesse Gabriel. "It's about coming together and grieving our loss."

Speakers at the event stood between U.S., California and United Nations flags on Sproul Plaza.

Across campus, student groups offered their own commemorations of Sept. 11.

Several student groups collaborated to produce a two-hour panel discussing issues that ethnic minorities face in the aftermath of Sept. 11.

"For the first time, (we're) bringing minority groups together to talk about the effects after 9/11," said UC Berkeley senior Arefa Vohra, who participated in the panel. "Talking about the effects of post-9/11 was always considered taboo."

To give students another forum to express their thoughts on the attacks of Sept. 11, the ASUC and Graduate Assembly organized an open microphone session.

"It's significant to be able to voice one's opinion in order to maintain the individual liberties that make our democracy great," said senior political science major Lily Moallem.

Many students wrote their thoughts on large sheets of paper unfurled before Sproul Hall, as event organizers collected donations for the families of those killed by the attacks.

Earlier in the day, dozens of students, faculty and Berkeley residents from various religious faiths held an Interfaith Circle of Remembrance sponsored by the University Religious Council.

Participants said they wanted to break prejudices that have resurfaced this year.

"It's wonderful that so many faiths are coming together right now to erase some of the prejudices that they have against each other," said university employee Marty Rawlings, who attended the circle.

The International House also centered their memorial around the idea of global unity, as residents released 50 doves as a "vision of world peace" on their front steps.

The day ended with a 9 p.m. candlelight vigil on Sproul Plaza, which was attended by thousands.

As students left with candles in hand, members of UC Berkeley ROTC continued to read names of the victims in last year's attacks. Starting at 5:45 a.m. yesterday, they continued their 24-hour observance.

"What we're doing is reinforcing that they led significant lives," said UC Berkeley student and cadet Emmanuel Cao. "It helps us remember that people who died could have been one of us."

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